

Make us worthy of mercy, O Theotokos, fountain of tenderness. Look upon a people that has sinned, and reveal thy power as always, for we have put our hope in thee. Rejoice, we cry to thee, as once did Gabriel, the leader of the bodiless hosts.

**DEACON:** Let us pray to the Lord.

Standing before the holy doors, with bowed head the **PRIEST** says this prayer:

**O** LORD, stretch forth thy hand from thy holy dwelling place on high, and strengthen me for this thine appointed service, that, standing uncondemned before thy dread throne, I may offer the bloodless sacrifice. For thine is the power and the glory unto ages of ages. Amen.

They turn and bow to each other and, turning west, they bow to the people. They enter the sanctuary as the **DEACON** says:

**I** WILL enter thy house; I will worship toward thy holy temple in the fear of thee. Lead me, O Lord, in thy righteousness because of mine enemies; make my way straight before thee. For there is no truth in their mouth, their heart

is destruction, their throat is an open sepulcher, they flatter with their tongue. Judge them, O God, let them fall by their own counsels; because of their many transgressions cast them out, for they have rebelled against thee. But let all who take refuge in thee rejoice, let them always sing for joy; and do thou dwell in them, that those who love thy Name may exult in thee. For thou blessest the righteous, O Lord; thou coverest us with good will as with a shield. (Ps. 5: 8–13)

Then they bow three times before the holy table (or they make prostrations when appointed), and the priest kisses the holy Gospel and the holy table while the deacon kisses only the holy table. Then each takes his sticharion and bows three times towards the east, saying within himself: O God, cleanse me, a sinner, and have mercy on me.

